

# 1955 ▶ 1960

**1955**

## Velcro patented

After studying the tiny hooks of burdock seeds that stuck to his clothes, Swiss engineer George de Mestral invented and patented a new fastening system. Velcro consisted of two strips of material—one with thousands of tiny hooks that catch and latch onto the thousands of loops on the second strip. By 1959, 164 million ft (50 million m) of Velcro was produced each year.

**1955**

## Wireless remote

American electrical engineer Eugene Polley invented the first cable-free TV remote control. Called the Zenith Flash-Matic, it featured a light beam that users directed at one of four corners of their TV set. Photocells on the TV received the light and could change channels, mute the sound, or switch the set on or off.



*Pressing the trigger operated the controller.*

**Zenith Flash-matic TV remote control**

*Controller held a lamp that sent out a beam of light.*

**1957**

## Bubble wrap

American inventors Alfred Fielding and Marc Chavannes developed bubble wrap—a plastic material consisting of small pockets filled with air. After use as a 3-D wallpaper, in shower curtains, and as insulation for greenhouses, bubble wrap eventually gained popularity as lightweight packaging.

*Spherical body weighed 178.5 lb (81 kg) and contained three silver-zinc batteries.*

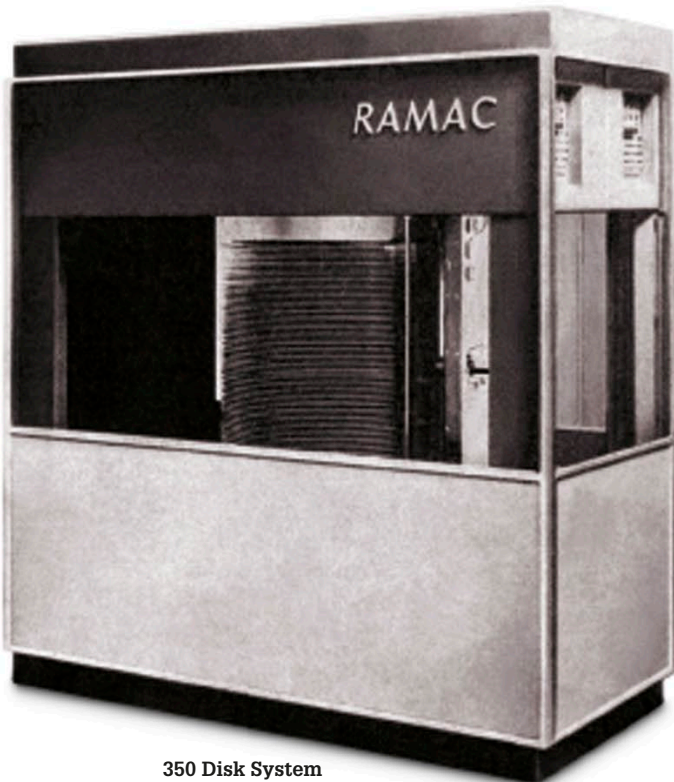
*Four radio antennae broadcasted signals to Earth.*



**Sputnik 1**  
The first artificial satellite was launched by the Soviet Union (now Russia) in 1957. Sputnik 1 was a 23-in- (58-cm-) diameter metal sphere fitted with batteries and a radio transmitter that relayed signals to Earth for 21 days (see p.212).



**1955**



**350 Disk System**

**1956**

## First hard disk

The 350 Disk System—the first hard disk drive—was launched by IBM for its 305 RAMAC computer. It stood 5.64 ft (1.72 m) tall, weighed almost a ton, and stored 3.75 megabytes of data on magnetic platters (rotating disks).

**1956**

## Vitamin B12

British biochemist Dorothy Hodgkin published the structure of Vitamin B12. Found in meat, fish, and dairy products, this vitamin helps the body produce healthy red blood cells. A shortage of B12 in the body can lead to a form of anemia.



**The National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) agency was established in 1958.**

*Edmund Hillary*

